

Domes

The Roman development of concrete made it possible to build large, hemispherical domes. These became a major feature of Byzantine churches, especially once builders began using pendentives or squinches (corner supports) to mount them on rectangular buildings. Because of their comparatively shallow shape, Roman domes are sometimes described as 'saucer' domes. Islamic architects often created pointed or bulbous domes – such as on the Taj Mahal at Agra, India – which can be compared to the onion-shaped dome used in Russia, Germany and eastern Europe. In Italy, both Brunelleschi and Michelangelo designed double-shelled domes that were hemispherical internally, but slightly pointed externally to direct the weight more downward than outward; both the inner and outer domes rest on a circular drum, which is often set with windows. St Paul's Cathedral in London is a triple-shelled dome. Compound domes are groups of multiple domes on one building, as seen on, for instance, St Basil's in Moscow. Generally, domes are crowned with a lantern or cupola.



Interior dome of St Peter's Basilica, Rome